First News

17 Mar 2026

Employing Intelligent investing, a disciplined, long-term approach to wealth creation based on fundamental analysis, risk management, and emotional control.

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Global, Regional Markets

Wall Street finished sharply higher on Monday as major indices staged their best performance since the start of the conflict in Iran. Retreating Oil Prices, Hopes for Strait of Hormuz Reopening, Renewed Momentum in AI Tech as the Nvidia GTC conference kicked off.

Trump demands allies & major oil importers to join a naval coalition Japan / Australia: Declined to send ships. UK: Sending mine-hunting drones only. South Korea: Staying neutral; no commitment. France: Willing but "muted" response. China: Unlikely to join due to Iran ties.

Bitcoin's recent climb above $74,000 has put the $80,000 psychological milestone back in play, faces a steep "resistance ladder" first The USA, Israel, and Iran in late February and early March 2026, Bitcoin's price hit a low of approximately $63,062.

Brent Crude: Settled above $100 for a third consecutive session, the longest such streak since August 2022.

- Volatility Drivers: Prices have surged more than 42% since the conflict began on February 28 following US-Israeli strikes on Iran.

Nvidia also unveiled the Groq 3 Language Processing Unit (LPU), the first chip resulting from its $20 billion asset purchase of the startup Nvidia also teased Rubin Ultra and the next-generation Feynman architectures for 2027 and 2028, respectively

- Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang announced that the company expects to generate at least $1 trillion in cumulative revenue from its Blackwell and Rubin architectures through the end of 2027.

BYD Co. shares surged in HK on Monday, leading a rally in Chinese electric-vehicle stocks, driven by reports that its Brazilian plant secured 100,000 orders from Mexico and Argentina

Overseas Funds Flow Monday 3/16/26 Bought Equities Indonesia $60.3 m Sold Equities Taiwan $1.43 billion India $1.17 billion S. Korea $904.6 m Thailand $159.6 m Malaysia $44.7 m Philippines $6.7m

Asian stock futures are pointing toward a positive open this Tuesday, March 17, 2026, as receding oil prices and a strong overnight performance on Wall Street boosted investor sentiment.

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Asia-Pacific

	3/16/2026	3/17/2026	%Chg
Dow Jones	46,558	46,946	0.83%
S&P 500	6,632	6,699	1.01%
NASDAQ	22,105	22,374	1.22%
PCOMP	6,113.58	6,113.58	0.00%
NKY	53,819.61	54,081.84	0.49%
SHCOMP	4095.45	4084.79	-0.26%
HSI	25,465.60	25,834.02	1.45%
KOSPI	5487.24	5697.19	3.83%
SENSEX	74,563.92	75,502.85	1.26%
TWSE	33,400	33,343	-0.17%
ASX200	8617.09	8588.4	-0.33%
BURSAKLCI	1698.85	1696.56	-0.13%
JCI	7137.21	7022.29	-1.61%
STI	4842.27	4868.69	0.55%
SET	936.5	933.25	-0.35%
VNINDEX	1696.24	1693.21	-0.18%

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Commodities - Metals & Agriculture

	3/16/2026	3/17/2026	%Chg
WTI Crude	98.71	95.74	-3.01%
Brent Crude	103.14	102.56	-0.56%
Gold (Comex)	5061.7	5010.7	-1.01%
Silver (Comex)	81.34	80.65	-0.85%
Platinum Spot	2028.32	2111.11	4.08%
Copper (Comex)	575.7	582.8	1.23%
Nickel	7.7236	7.8721	1.92%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.5%	80	80	0.00%
Nickel Ore Phl 1.8%	94.5	94.5	0.00%
Coal	137.3	135	-1.68%
Corn	467.25	457.75	-2.03%
Wheat	613.75	604.5	-1.51%
Cocoa	3297	3418	3.67%
Sugar	14.37	14.19	-1.25%

Strategy

Philippines

The Philippine peso hit an all-time low of ₱59.97 per dollar today, nearing the ₱60 threshold and forcing the central bank to intervene. To stabilize fuel costs and supply, the government is negotiating energy deals with Indonesia and Russia.

The Philippine House of Representatives approved House Bill 8418 on its third and final reading on March 16, 2026, granting the President the power to temporarily suspend or reduce excise taxes on petroleum products.

NOTES

- This "bottom of the barrel" crisis, characterized by skyrocketing fuel oil costs and diminished supply, threatens to paralyze global shipping

DA MARKET SECURITIES

Philippines

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6006 -52.93 pts., -0.86%

Range 5,970.32-6,048.98

Breadth 53 (+) 153 (-) 53 (unch)

Block Php3.65B **Volume** 3.29B **Value** Php9.53B

Share buyback sm ict opm spmh meg

52wk H: opm
52wk L: ali allhc atn bhi bloom bpi c chp dito ferro idc medic om pa pal prim vlc

Overbought – none
Oversold – tugs lbc bpi pa tech vlc pmpc ferro gtcap ssi

Active	Value
ICT	988
JFC	442
BPI	381
BDO	316
PLUS	294
URC	272
SM	216
MBT	214
PX	167

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Foreign Trade

NFB(S)	$6.682mn
Total FB Feb	$20.111mn
YTD NFB	$245.931mn

FB	3,168,469,845.24
FS	3,568,622,447.35
NFB(S)	400,152,602.11
TOTAL	6,737,092,292.59

Foreign Funds Bought
bdo mbt dhi slf ap mwc mynld shlph dnl keepr aba ac cosco jgs ddmpr meg mreit rock ceb mac sti bloom plus rrhi wlcon apx nikl pxp

Foreign Funds Sold
bpi cbc pnb ubp acen fgen fph mer pcor scc sgp spnec axlm cnpf emi fb gsmi jfc monde pizza rfm urc aev agi dmc gtcap lpz ltg sm smc ali areit cli filrt mrc rcr rlc smph dito glo tel cnvrg now ict web mrsgi pgold at ogp px

SmartWatch Tuesday 3/17/26
ICT AP WEB MRC DMC RCR BDO BPI AC JGS MYNLD MWC AC AP STI COSCO NEG MAC NIKL AP

10yr Bond	3/16/20...	3/17/2...	%Chg
PHL	6.099	6.712	10.05%
US	4.187	4.235	1.15%

Currency Pair	3/16/2...	3/17/2...	%Chg
USD-JPY	157.71	159.29	0.64%
USD-PHP	58.916	59.898	0.06%
USD-CNY	6.8695	6.8917	0.24%
EUR-USD	1.1639	1.1492	-0.35%

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

RCR 6.85
Rsi 29
Oversold
PT 7.70
BUY

- Occupancy & Stability: Maintained a high system-wide occupancy rate of 96%. Div Yield: 6.14% P/E Ratio: 4.6x, sobra lower than the peer average of 12x. P/B Ratio: 0.84, suggesting the stock trades at a discount to its book value

SMC 67.30 -2.60%

- San Miguel Corporation (SMC) delivers a massive 2025!
- Reported Net Income: ₱94.7B
- Core Net Income: ₱79.6B (+52% YoY)
- Revenue: ₱1.5 Trillion EBITDA: ₱262B (+16% YoY)
- Operational strength meets smart investment gains
- What’s driving the numbers?
- While ₱94.7B is the headline, core growth is the real story—up 52% to ₱79.6B.
- Gains were bolstered by: Fair valuation of investments Favorable FX movements
- Strong ₱181.6B operating income

AGRICULTURE / F&B

- The Department of Agriculture (DA) is considering a per kilogram price cap on imported rice as of March 16, 2026.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PSE MARKET CONSTRAINTS — Companies Weighing Overseas Listings
Analysts from COL Financial, Philstocks, Unicapital, and BDO Securities flagged a structural headwind: the PSE's thin liquidity, subdued risk appetite, and limited capital-raising depth are driving high-growth companies to consider foreign listings. JFC is exploring a US exchange listing for its international arm; digital wallet Maya is evaluating a US IPO for higher fintech valuations and liquidity. BDO Securities noted that these moves highlight PSE's current inability to provide adequate price discovery and depth for high-growth business models.

DA View: A structural headwind for PSEi broadening. Watch for PSE regulatory responses (lower minimum public ownership thresholds, market-maker expansion). Near-term, blue-chip concentration in the PSEi likely deepens.

PNB HOLDINGS CORP. (PHC) — SEC Clears PSE Listing by Way of Introduction
The SEC approved PNB Holdings Corp. (PHC), PNB's real estate arm, for a PSE listing by way of introduction — allowing existing shares to trade publicly without raising fresh capital. This follows PNB's distribution of its 51% PHC stake as property dividends to shareholders. As of February 2026, 98.08% of the dividends had been distributed. Once listed, PHC's shareholder base will expand to 30,000+ investors. PNB shares fell 2.04% to P55.10 on Monday.

DA View: PHC listing adds a Lucio Tan-backed property vehicle to the PSE. No fresh capital raised at listing. Stance: MONITOR pending listing date.

ICTSI (ICT) — Pier 14 Structural Upgrade Ahead of Schedule at NorthPort
ICTSI's NorthPort subsidiary completed the second and third 42.5-meter segments of the Pier 14 structural upgrade ahead of schedule. Work has advanced to the fourth and final 52.5-meter segment (as of February 2026), including deck resurfacing, damage repair, and upgrading fenders from 700mm to 1,000mm cell fenders. The full program is expected to complete in 2027. ICTSI is also raising 2026 capex by 14% to $740 million to fund expansions at MICT, NorthPort, and multiple international terminals. FY2025 profits reached $1.05 billion (+23%). ICTSI was one of just two PSEi gainers on Monday (+1.46%).

DA View: ICTSI's ahead-of-schedule execution and diversified global portfolio make it a relative safe haven amid geopolitical stress. Stance: ACCUMULATE.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

PHINMA CORP. — Acquires 84.91% of Southeastern College for P690M
PHINMA Education Holdings Inc. (a PHINMA Corp. subsidiary) completed the P690 million acquisition of an 84.91% controlling stake in Southeastern College Inc. in Pasay City on March 13, 2026. The school (founded 1946) offers undergraduate programs in education, computer science, and business administration. It becomes PHINMA Education's 12th institution in the Philippines and 14th across its regional network (including Indonesia). The Pasay campus joins the PHINMA Saint Jude College NCR network. Combined, PHINMA Education now serves approximately 178,000 students. The deal is expected to serve ~80,000 students in southern Metro Manila, Laguna, and Cavite.

A View: PHINMA's disciplined bolt-on education acquisitions continue to expand enrollment base at reasonable valuations. Stance: ACCUMULATE for medium-term holders.

FILINVEST LAND (FLI) — Files SEC Application for 3rd Tranche of P35B Bond Program
Filinvest Land filed a registration statement with the SEC on March 13, 2026 for up to P9 billion in bonds (with up to P2.57 billion oversubscription option; total potential: P11.57 billion). This is the third tranche of FLI's P35-billion shelf-registered peso bond program (approved October 2023). Three sub-series: 3.5-year (due 2029), 5-year (due 2031), and 10-year (due 2036) bonds. Proceeds will refinance debt and fund residential and retail expansions outside Metro Manila. Joint lead underwriters include BDO Capital, BPI Capital, China Bank Capital, and First Metro. FLI shares fell 1.30% to P0.76 on Monday.
DA View: FLI's continued use of shelf-registered bonds to fund provincial expansion is strategically sound. Stance: MONITOR — watch for bond pricing terms.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

AP 45.45

SN ABOITIZ POWER (SNAP) — Battery Storage Portfolio Expanding to 160MW

SN Aboitiz Power (a JV between Aboitiz Renewables and Norway's Scatec ASA) is building toward 160 MW of total battery energy storage system (BESS) capacity (operational + under construction). Currently: 80 MW under construction across Binga and Ambuklao hydropower plants in Benguet (financial close achieved February 3, 2026), plus a 16 MW Magat BESS expansion in Isabela — both targeting commercial operations by mid-2026. A further 80 MW notice to proceed has been issued, targeting 2027. The BESS portfolio provides fast-response ancillary services to the Luzon grid and supports the Philippines' energy transition goals.

DA View: SNAP's BESS build-out is well-positioned for a post-Middle East-crisis energy security narrative domestically. Ironically, the oil shock may accelerate renewable-plus-storage investment. Stance on AboitizPower: ACCUMULATE.

CEB 30.65

- **CEBU PACIFIC (CEB) — Reviewing Fuel Costs & Network Strategy Amid Oil Surge**
- Cebu Pacific CEO Michael B. Szucs confirmed the airline is closely reviewing jet fuel costs and network strategies in response to sharply rising oil prices linked to the Middle East conflict. Mitigating factors: 70%+ of CEB's jet fleet uses fuel-efficient NEO technology (15–20% lower fuel burn), and limited Middle East route exposure. January-February 2026 passenger traffic reached 5.07 million (+7% year-on-year); February load factor was 85.6%. However, the airline flagged that sustained fuel cost increases may necessitate fare adjustments or capacity reductions.

DA View — CEB: Fuel is CEB's single largest cost and the biggest earnings risk in the current environment. NEO fleet advantage provides partial offset. Stance: WAIT — monitor oil price trajectory before adding.

CNVRG 12.70

- **CONVERGE ICT (CNVRG) — Minimal Middle East Exposure; P23B Capex Proceeding**
- **C**onverge ICT COO Benjamin B. Azada confirmed that the Middle East crisis is expected to have minimal near-term impact on business. The sole potential exposure is its fleet of field vehicles — a portion of which still use internal combustion engines — but these represent a small fraction of the company's cost base. Converge reiterated its P23 billion 2026 capex program for network expansion into Visayas (Capiz, Samar) and Northern Mindanao (Bukidnon, Davao de Oro, Sultan Kudarat), with 100,000+ new ports targeted this year. FY2025 revenues: P44.8 billion (+10.2%); enterprise revenues grew 20.3%. Revenue guidance: 8-10% growth for 2026.

DA View — CNVRG: Converge's low energy-price sensitivity is a near-term positive differentiator. Enterprise business momentum is the key upside driver. Stance: ACCUMULATE.

NEWS, ANALYSIS , INVESTING INSIGHT

MPI
GTCAP 560.00
METRO PACIFIC INVESTMENTS (MPIC) — mWell Wins 2026 GLOMO Award at Mobile World Congress

- MPIC's digital health platform mWell won the Global Mobile (GLOMO) Award for Best Mobile Innovation Supporting Emergency or Humanitarian Situations (Tech4Good category) at Mobile World Congress 2026 in Barcelona on March 4. This is mWell's second GLOMO win (following 2023's Best Mobile Innovation for Digital Life) and makes it the first Philippine healthtech app to win in this category. Winners were selected by 250+ independent experts. mWell joins Apple, Samsung, Huawei, China Mobile, and China Telecom among 2026 GLOMO awardees.
- mWell (together with KonsultaMD) serves 7.3 million users, with 37% from vulnerable/underserved sectors. The platform has deployed 179 portable OnTheGo clinic units serving nearly 891,000 people across 17 Indigenous communities. mWell is also expanding OFW healthcare access via OWWA and DMW partnerships.

DA View — MPIC: mWell's international recognition adds a positive rerating narrative for MPIC's health tech portfolio. The eKonsulta decommissioning (July 2026) could accelerate user migration to mWell. Stance: ACCUMULATE.